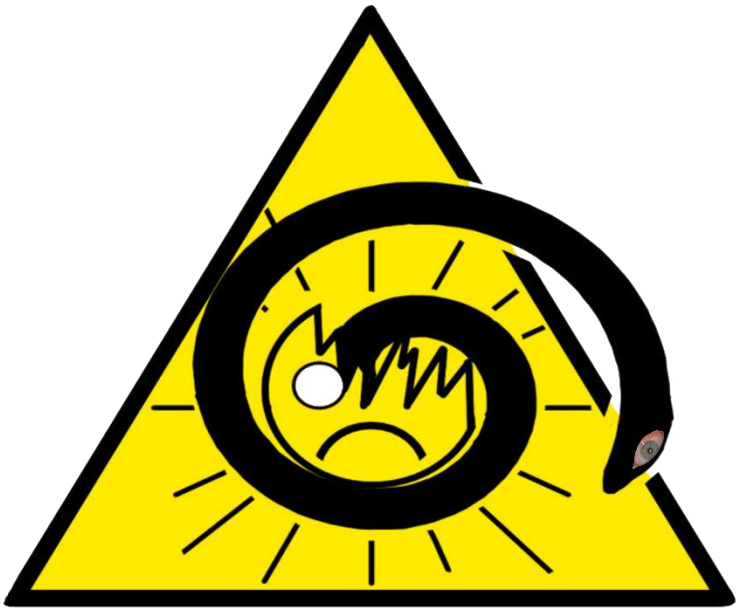


The Star Driven Expulsion of Count Lastname

"Oh Luisa! You're something else!"

By Taino Marotto Spain

Count – Devin Redor
Margo – Jazara Metcalf

Hera – Lily Burkin
William – Wilhelm Scholz
Elpis – Zephyr Dressel
Waiter – Maddie McLaughlin
Bellboy(Fatherless) – Callen Lionetti

Luisa - TBA
Nancy - TBA
Father - TBA

Automated Voice (Voicemail)- Sanoja Sridevan
Automated Voice (Elevator) – AJ Sohrabi
Automated Voice (TV) – Maddie McLaughlin
Automated Voice (Apollo Suites + Apollo) – Aron Eskenazi
Automated Voice (Zeus)- AJ Sohrabi
Automated Voice (Posideon)- Wilhelm Scholz
Automated Voice (Sauna + Fire)- Sanoja Sridevan

Automated Voice (Jackpot)- Wilhelm Scholz
Clotho – Aron Eskenazi
Lachesis – Callen Lionetti
Atropos – AJ Sohrabi

Thing (Rat) – Taino Marotto Spain
Others (Plural) – Ensemble
Thing (Big) – Ensemble

_____

Anything in brackets implies what the character would say if they were not cut off. It is likely lines should be learned including what's in brackets, or at least emphasise the importance that the actor understands the intention of the whole line.

Count has clothes underneath his gown.

I

(A room. The blinds are drawn tight. Gentle breathing. Distant sounds of cars and horns. Knock on the door.)

BELLBOY: Good Morning! Breakfast!

(No response.)

(A second knock)

BELLBOY: Anyone in? Breakfast!

(Muffled Groaning, movement of bedsheets.)

COUNT: Later!

BELLBOY: Of course, have a good day!

(Squeaking of trolley. Another knock, quieter, further down the hall)

(Muffled) BELLBOY: Good Morning! Breakfast!

(A very deep, low rumble. Quiet scream and shouting begins. A long blare of a car horn before a single crack. Silence, with the rumble. And then another crack. Another, in quick succession, before lots of little cracks before the rumble becomes overly loud and a deep explosion, followed by a long, piercing call, eldritch and gargantuan. Then more screams begin, cracking and crashing. All muffled and distant.)

(Movement in bedsheets. A groan. A remote is grabbed, and a button is pressed.)

Automated Voice (TV): Olympus on Air. The Athenium's Premier Streaming Service.

(The TV begins playing a dating show. The volume is turned up. ARGENTINE (Calm) plays in background.)

FATHER: Listen to me, hija. She is dangerous. I will not have my daughter be *corrupted* by a woman like that.

NANCY: But papa, I-

FATHER: Enough! You will not disrespect my wishes! I am your father, and you will obey me!

[FATHER slams the door. NANCY begins sobbing]

(Knocking on the door, again. More sluggish, like something being hit against the door. Begins to turn into a bashing. The show continues playing in the background. [A window is opened. LUISA climbs in])

(Nothing)

(Bashing again)

COUNT: I said come back later!

(The bashing continues. COUNT gives a sigh of exasperation, and gets up. Making his way towards the door. The music begins rising, slowly increasing in volume.)

NANCY: Luisa, how did you get in here?

LUISA: Cállate, my love. I am here now. That is all that matters.

(COUNT opens the door)

COUNT: Listen kid, I get you're fishing for tips but (emphasised) I'm not hungr-

(Sound of a door opening. A singular chord on the song.)

(COUNT sees the OTHER staring back at him, holding a breakfast trolley. The OTHER is a deep violet-black colouration. The two eyes have peeled open like oranges to reveal a cluster of tentacles, small mushroom-like striations, and jagged, disarrayed teeth. You can still see various human features, like an ear, or the collarbone ssssjutting through.)

COUNT (Whispered): What the fuck…

NANCY: But Luis-

(A singular chord, again)

OTHER-BELLBOY: (In a gargled, wet indentation, barely coherent): Breakfast.

(The chord is repeated twice as fast.)

LUISA: Hush, mosa. Dance with me. One last time.

COUNT: I think you have the wrong… (door)

(The OTHER-BELLBOY screams, and charges at COUNT. ARGENTINE begins in full.)

(COUNT screams, and stumbles backwards, knocking into a desk behind him. The creature pounces and knocks him to the ground. A vase is knocked, and shatters.)

COUNT: Get off of- me!

(The creature, gurgling, opens its mouth, and tries to bite down - a screeching sound, and the sound of wood being split. COUNT moves his head to the side, and pulls away. Stands up, staggering backwards.)

COUNT: Jesus Christ!

(The creature gets up, its tentacles writhing. Steps on the shattered glass.)

COUNT: What are you?

(The other lunges at COUNT, who is stood in front of the TV, he ducks to the side and it collides with the TV, which falls into its side. The TV screen cracks.)

NANCY (DISTORTING): Oh, Luisa! You're something else!

COUNT: Fuck me- I-

(COUNT collides with a wall, with a loud smash. He cries out)

(COUNT groans. The other hisses, and approaches COUNT)

COUNT: Wait! Let me just-

(COUNT stumbles and hits a switch on the wall. A singular click is heard. There is silence for a moment. The song is at a calmer point.)

COUNT: -turn on the lights. If only I was being attacked by a moth.

(Pause)

OTHER-BELLBOY: (Heavily gargled) Bright.

(Silence for a moment. A few strings are plucked.)

COUNT: (Breathing heavily) No god-damn way. You never seen a lamp before, pal? (squid?) (slimey?)

(Another beat)

COUNT: Well let me *illuminate* you!

(Ascending series of notes in the song, before full swing.)

(COUNT grabs the LAMP, and the sound of a plug being ripped out a socket. He cries out, and the lamp makes contact with the creature, a loud, squelching noise as the lamp crumples. COUNT hits the

creature once, twice, once-twice once more before whimpering and running.)

(COUNT exits the room, the distorted TV and the gurgles of the creature fading, when he collides with a breakfast trolley, which rattles and a plate falls off.)

COUNT: Fuck! Who left the breakfast trolle- Where did that kid go? Hello?

(A gurgle from inside the room.)

COUNT: God damn. Never trust a bellboy. Unless he-

(The OTHER steps into the hallway. It gurgles again.)

COUNT: Ah.

OTHER-BELLBOY: Breakfaast.

COUNT: Can't take a hint, can you? (To self) There's no way I can outrun that thing. Do I throw myself out the window? It can't be that far dow-

OTHER-BELLBOY: Suuun.

COUNT: (To the Other) Shut up. Thinking. I could throw *it* out the window. Window's a good twenty feet away though. If I could just-

(THE OTHER gargles, and lunges at COUNT. He cries out, and grabs the trolley. He hits the OTHER slightly, and it staggers back a few feet.)

COUNT: Take the trolley and-

(The OTHER gargles. COUNT grabs the trolley, and begins rolling it towards the OTHER. There is a squelch as they collide.

COUNT: *Push it-*

(The OTHER screeches, and COUNT pushes them both down the hallway)

COUNT: Don’t think I can give you a tip, but what I can do is give you-

(before releasing the trolley, which rolls down the hallway)

A raise!

(The trolley collides with a huge glass window, which shatters as the OTHER falls out the window, into the early morning sky, screeching as it gets quieter. A distant, distant thud.)

(COUNT stands, panting for air.)

COUNT: Fuck. No wonder the hospitality industries dying out.

(COUNT walks over into his room. The TV is now static and disconnected. Reaches for a dial phone. Calls.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (VOICEMAIL): Good Morning! You have reached the front desk of the Atheneum Resort and Casino.

COUNT: Hello, yes, I'd like to report a- uh- creature-

AUTOMATED VOICE (VOICEMAIL): None of our staff are currently available to take your call. Please leave a message after the tone or make your way to Floor 124 for your nearest Visitor Support Desk.

COUNT: Figures.

(COUNT drops the phone, leaves the dial tone, which blends with the static. COUNT brushes himself down. Sprays something into his mouth, and begins strolling down the hallway.)

COUNT (Fading out): Caesar's Palace was offering to comp food, but you just had to go to the place that… (offered the fucking bathtubs that had the lights under the water. Why did you care so much? They weren't even that bright. The water barely changed colour.)

(The static and dialtone grows and merges)

(Cuts abruptly to a heavy pluck every bar. Sound of door opening.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (APOLLO): Welcome to the Apollo Suites. Please do not touch the decorations.

COUNT (whistles): God damn. I didn't realise they made vases that big.

(Silence. Hello echoes slightly.)

COUNT: Hello? Anyone around? Off-season must be a killer. How much are they paying for these lights?

(Intercom sound)

HERA: Good Godly Morning, esteemed mortals of the Atheneum. I am, as usual, your resident God, Hera, here to tell you the news, truths and dues of this wonderful day, making sure you remain comfortable, convenienced, contented, and cognisant during your time here in Olympus.
First of all, on behalf of the entirety of the Pantheon, I would like to formally apologise for the disruption that befell upon our little heaven this morning. Securities had some reports that- sorry- Hermes has had a fly around the resort and found that there is a

disturbance unfolding within the outer world, but it doesn't appear to be a threat for those within the casino, good mortals.

COUNT: Psh, bullshit.

If anyone was shaken, scared, or in any way inconvenienced by the noise, please inform the front desk, and you will be compensated with a voucher for a free spin on any of the slot machines currently participating in the Fates Fortune events. That's Floors 20 through 35. Twenty through Thirty Five. If gambling isn't your dance, we also have chocolate.

COUNT: Ah! Here we are.

(COUNT reaches an elevator. Presses a button. The elevator dings once again, as it descends.)

HERA: As always, if you have any queries, don't hesitate to reach out to your closest cupbearer - they're here to help! If you have any complaints, please make your way to the front desk so we can formally submit a grievance form. And if you have any comments or complaints specifically in relation to any money lost through any of our games here at the resort, please make your way to the nearest support desk, available on every games floor.
Lastly, don't forget that there is still time to get a ticket for the chance to win a brand new Ford Chariot, the monster truck fit for a God. Just make your way down to the nearest gift shop to enrol in the casino-wide raffle. This is your resident God Hera signing off, wishing you a wonderous day!

(The gentle song ends with a ding, as the door opens to the elevator. MARGO is pointing a gun at COUNT)

COUNT: Hello.

MARGO: Hello.

(Beat)

What's with the bathrobe?

COUNT: Would you care to enlighten me as to why there's a gun currently pointed at my head?

MARGO: The worlds ending and you're wearing a bathrobe?

COUNT: Why is the gun still pointed at me?

MARGO: Because it's the end of the world and I can't trust the fact your head isn't gonna explode into tentacles and try and kill me and then I'm going to have regretted not having a gun aimed at you, aren't I?

COUNT: Tenta- You've seen those things too?

MARGO: Ya.

COUNT: What are they?

MARGO: (I-Don't-Know-Esque Sound)

COUNT: Why are they here?

MARGO (Very matter-of-factly): Because the worlds- (ending)

COUNT: Because the worlds ending, I forgot, I'm sorry, it must have slipped my mind somehow.

MARGO: Now you're just making fun of me.

COUNT: Strong words from someone who was just mocking my robe.

MARGO: Because it looks like a bathrobe.

COUNT: Of course it looks like a bathrobe- (, what do you think bathrobes were styled off in the first place?)

MARGO: Because it's a bathrobe?

COUNT: It's n-

(Pause)

COUNT: It's meant to look regal.

MARGO: Mm. What about the slippers?

COUNT: Look, I've had a rough morning, and I'm not interested in getting fashion advice from the barrel of a gun-

MARGO: Don't get me wrong, I'm just as surprised as you are, man, I was expecting to find some alien- tentacle- thing waiting outside this door but instead there's just, y'know. If you're taking all the Greek- Royalty stuff seriously then I'm not gonna judge you-

(The elevator closes on COUNT, and muffles MARGO. COUNT sighs and presses the button on the elevator. The Elevator opens again)

(Beat)

MARGO: What?

COUNT: Oh, I'm sorry, I was hoping I had just hallucinated the six-foot five skinhead that apparently haunts this elevator.

MARGO: Boo. Are you getting in?

COUNT: Are you going to put the gun down?

MARGO: I'll think about it.

(COUNT sighs. Gets in the elevator. It closes with a ding. The music fades in.)

MARGO: What floor?

COUNT: 124.

(MARGO presses a button)

AUTOMATED VOICE (ELEVATOR): Floor 124.

(Slight silence. The elevator starts moving.)

MARGO: Hate elevator music. Desk job of music composition.

(Slight beat)

COUNT: So you said you believe the worlds ending, correct?

MARGO: Not believe. Know. But yes, I do.

COUNT: Then what's with the… relaxed posture and… opinions on elevator music? (More Improvised)

MARGO: Not much else to do in this lift. Besides, I'm wearing two layers of tactical vests, combat boots, carrying a pistol, shotgun, and utility knife all on my person at this current moment.

COUNT: Goddamn-

MARGO: I have the *luxury* to talk about elevator music. You look about as prepared as- well you don't.

COUNT: Don’t what?

MARGO: Look prepared.

COUNT: Maybe not for pointing guns at strangers, but my skillset is more *honed*. See, my friend,

(Unzipping sound)

my personage holds-

(Little rattle)

Norton's Mint-Flavoured Breath Spray - sugar free -

(Clink)

A genuine, de facto Montecristo L'Aurore Lighter-

(Light shake)

And a pack of Camel Blues.

(Light Beat)

MARGO: Your skillset's smoking?

COUNT: *Smoothtalking*. Cigarette?

MARGO: Sure.

(Sound of a flame being sparked. MARGO breathes out)

MARGO: Haven't smoked in years.

COUNT: Well, good to have you back on the losing team.

MARGO: End of the world is a good enough occasion.

COUNT: You've said that a few times now.

MARGO: Yep.

COUNT: You serious?

MARGO: Mhm. KS dash five end of the world scenario. Sun hatches.

(Pause)

COUNT: Sun *hm?*

MARGO: Sun hatches. Sun's an egg. Thing comes out sun. World ends.

(Pause)

COUNT: Are you genuinely out of your fucking mind?

MARGO: Don't ask if you're not going to listen-

COUNT: (Slight Laugh) What is this? You sound like some, conspiracy theorist-

MARGO: I am.

(Pause)

COUNT: Can we go back to when you had the gun pulled on me? That was easier to deal with than this-

MARGO: I'm not trying to fuck with you. Honest to god. I've been following, drops-

COUNT: Drops?

MARGO: They’re- (Changes tact/way of explaining) There's a lot of websites- forums you can find online, there's a lot of information on the internet that you can find if you try hard enough.

COUNT: (Unimpressed) So you've been digging for photos of Bigfoot your entire life.

MARGO: (Laughs) Fuck no. I hate that kind of thing. It's so easy to dredge up anything on- literally whatever you can think of. Fake moon landings, flat earths, cryptids, you know what I'm talking about-

COUNT: I do.

MARGO: I'm not saying it's wrong, I'm saying its mainstream. If… buigfoot really was a real danger or conspiracy, we wouldn't hear so much about it all the damn time. Whatever threat that information could have held is so diluted at this point that it's basically useless. There are genuine things that people want to keep hidden. Real secrets. That's what I care about.

COUNT: Give me an example.

MARGO: You know the whole incident with the Swedish President and how he was exposed siphoning money from the crisis fund for that one earthquake?

COUNT: Mhm. I knew a few people who donated. Why?

MARGO: He didn't actually steal any money from it. It was election season and one of his opponents pulled a *lot* of strings to run his name into the ground.

COUNT: That- That's not that hard to believe, in all honesty.

MARGO: Well that's the thing- as soon as the world hears about a thread of truth, it gets blown up and, exaggerated and messed around until you get fucking- lizard people governments or-

COUNT: You don't believe reptiles run the world?

MARGO: I think everyone's too useless to have a worldwide cover-up of something. You always think you've covered all your bases, put *all* your skeletons in *all* your closets but something always gets out.

COUNT: Then how come nobody found out that the sun we spend all day living under/the big ball in the sky that gives us *life* is spawn to some kind of cosmic… (grasping for straws slightly before finding the word) bird?

MARGO: Give me one good reason as to how we could have proven the sun was an egg.

(Pause)

COUNT: Well y-

(Pause)

COUNT: Mm.

MARGO: They got lucky. The truth was so absurd that nobody would ever take it seriously even if they found out.

COUNT: Then how come you of all people knew?

MARGO: Pure fucking luck. I happened to be in the right place at the right time. There's this one privately funded laboratory in Southern Manhattan I heard was doing tests on this one galaxy a couple million light years away where there might be life, so I managed to get access into-

COUNT: Get access- I'm sorry, you broke into a laboratory?

MARGO: I wore a safety vest and said I was checking the insulation in the older parts of the building. You pull off shit like that and then try and believe that the world government is successfully covering up that the world is flat.

COUNT: Huh.

MARGO: But I have my head in a ceiling tile eavesdropping when this kid comes in yelling about how they've been running some kind of "Kantwell" readings on distant space objects and that there's all this interference in the readings from something much closer to us, and they pull up some kind of diagram of the sun on a projector screen and I shit you not the silhouette you can see inside it is shaped like a *worm.* Curled up in on itself, wriggling and pulsing just so fucking slightly.

COUNT: God Damn.

MARGO: You know what happens to that place? Shut down next month. There's a shopping mall there now. When I left, I- I stole some papers. I saw something I wasn’t meant to. But I have the proof. I have the evidence. The sun beast was real.

COUNT: And now you're in a casino.

MARGO: I always stay in casinos during off-seasons. A thousand empty rooms in this place. They don't give a shit if I knock the door down into one. I still get room service here.

COUNT: Fuck.

MARGO: Yep.

(Beat)

COUNT: I don’t believe you, by the way. You seem alright, but-

MARGO: Can't ask you to believe it. If you die, you die. Makes no difference to me.

COUNT: Fair enough.

(Pause. COUNT begins lighting a cigarette.)

COUNT: I never asked you your name.

MARGO: Margo.

COUNT: Margo. Count. Pleasure to make your acquaintance.

(Handshaking)

MARGO: Likewise.

COUNT: Where were you planning on going?

MARGO: Suddenly asking a lot of questions, aren't we?

COUNT: I just happened to remember we're only three hundred floors from the ground level and thought it was worth getting the important things out the way.

MARGO: (Slight laugh) Hm. Theres a parking lot in the Tartarus Level of the Casino. I was going to try my luck at stealing something and getting out of here. Getting off at the ground floor and taking the stairs from there.

(Pause)

MARGO: You?

COUNT: Well I was going to file a complaint about the quality of the workers they employ here but that point feels…

(Clang from above)

COUNT: Moot.

MARGO: Bad service?

COUNT: Overenthusiastic. Have you seen many other people around here?

(Distant wiggle. Hiss. Another Clang)

MARGO: Besides you and lady on the intercom? Not really. Five hundred floors of casino in early February will do that to you.

COUNT: Good for gambling though- I tell you, the way some of these dealers look at me when (it's just me and one other bum at the table, and I'm pulling in everything-)-

(The hissing sound is louder)

MARGO: Shh.

COUNT: You got to tell your alien story, it's only fair you hea-
(hear some of mine)

MARGO: No. There's something here. Listen.

(A moment of silence, other than the elevator music. A gentle slurping sound, the sound of metal being banged and picked at, and then the maintenance hatch falls with a clang.)

COUNT: (Slight Yelp) What is that?

MARGO: The maintenance hatch. Something's in the ceil-

(A slurping noise, a wet slap, like meat hitting a counter.)

COUNT: Is it dead?

MARGO: Hell if I know. Stand back.

(Pulling out of a gun.)

COUNT: It seems so much smaller than the one I saw before.

MARGO: Sh. I can't hear if it's breathing.

(Pause)

COUNT: I'm not sure if they breath-

(A loud trilling scream. The creature lunges at COUNT. The elevator music, which previously consisted of piano chords, a bass being plucked, and a quiet saxophone gains a drum set, supporting bass, and a piano melody, to swing it into a full jazz piece.)

MARGO: Shit-

COUNT: Oh my g-

(RAT misses COUNT and slams against the wall. MARGO fires three shots.)

COUNT: Jesus Christ Margo, you're gonna shoot me if you keep up like-

MARGO: Then get back!

COUNT: I'm trying!

(RAT gets up, and jumps at COUNT again. He screams and pushes back against a wall, hitting all the buttons)

AUTOMATED VOICE (ELEVATOR): Floor 341. Floor 567. Floor 128.

MARGO: Get off the controls!

COUNT: It's on me! It's on me!

MARGO: Throw your robe around it!

(COUNT cries out, and rips the robe slightly, throwing the creature like a baseball wrapped in cloth, it thuds and hits the wall)

COUNT: I swear on my life Margo, you’re going to end up killing me with that gun-

MARGO: Because you're in the way!

COUNT: It's hard not to in a five foot square elevator.

MARGO: F- Just get on the fucking- handrail so I can get actually shoot at the thing!

COUNT: Okay!

(COUNT climbs up onto the handrail. Sound of squeaky metal as the creature struggles with the fabric. MARGO fires multiple times into the robe)

COUNT (Moaning): My robe…

MARGO: There.

COUNT: You owe me a new robe.

MARGO: Nope.

COUNT: I-

(Shuffling of fabric. Light trill.)

MARGO: It's not dead?

COUNT: The sleeve! It's coming out the sleev-

COUNT: Margo!

(A screech as RAT jumps at MARGO, who kicks it, sending it flying across the room)

MARGO: It's too damn small to get a hit on it. I need-

(MARGO drops the handgun, it clatters. They start reaching for a shotgun, cocks it.)

COUNT: You're fucking kidding me.

MARGO: This is better.

COUNT: Margo, you are smarter than this. Do not fire that shotgun in this enclosed elevator. It-

MARGO (Through gritted teeth): Unless you have a way to kill this thing before it rips your arm off-

(The creature adjusts, and hisses again, charging at MARGO)

MARGO: We're just gonna- (do this the hard way)

(Shotgun burst. COUNT screams.)

COUNT: It's on the wall-

MARGO: Come on, you f- (ucking)

(A second shot. The creature starts slurping over the controls)

LIFT
COUNT: Not the controls! The cont-

(A third shot, hitting the elevator control panel.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (ELEVATOR): Floor 12- (The speaker is blown out with the shot.)

MARGO: Nearly… and-

(RAT jumps at MARGO, hissing and leaping.)

MARGO: Goodbye, you little-

(A shot, sound of a water balloon filled with worms exploding, as RAT is burst into a million pieces.)

(Both stand, gasping for air.)

MARGO: What's your skillset to a shotgun, huh?

COUNT: What's a shotgun to the controls to an elevator?

MARGO: What's- (Notices) Ah.

COUNT: Caught up in the moment a little, were you?

MARGO: Saving someone's life will do that.

COUNT: Mm.

(Pause, as they catch their breath)

COUNT: I'm not ungrateful, to be clear. Just wish we could have done something a little more…

MARGO: Safe?

COUNT: Delicate.

MARGO: Noted.

(Beat)

COUNT: You take criticism well. I thought you'd be more angry at my complaint.

MARGO: Who knows? Maybe I've blown off a little steam in the past couple minutes.

COUNT: Noted.

(Pause)

COUNT: I don't know if I'd agree.

MARGO: Hm?

COUNT: It's not really a desk job. Elevator music. Feels more like an obituary.

MARGO: Heh.

(The Elevator suddenly stops whirring. The distorted music slows and turns off. The lights turn off.)

MARGO: Damn. Was hoping it'd take us straight to the ground floor.

COUNT: Wanted to get a good look at the fancy monster truck, hm?

MARGO: Already have. It's got an ELPISthat drives you around and everything. Help me pull the doors open.

(Close scene)

(Open scene with grunting, and thick doors pulling open. MARGO grunts and hits the floor.)

MARGO: All good. You can jump down.

COUNT: Will you catch me?

MARGO: Maybe.

(COUNT grunts and hits the floor in the family guy death pose)

MARGO: Nice fall.

COUNT: Nice catch. Where are we?

MARGO: It's at least two hundred floors from the base.

(In synchrony with COUNT)
MARGO + COUNT: Looks like a casino floor. (Bleeds immediately into COUNTS next line)

COUNT: Goddamn, you hit the jackpot on when you fucked up the elevator controls. Look at all these slot machines!

MARGO: you do know you were staying in a casino, yeah?

COUNT: Margo, darling, you don't know what you've walked us into. See these one-armed wonders all around us?

(COUNT hits a machine like a car. It makes a hollow clunk)

Make SID-RS-1995. Went out of production two decades ago. You know why?

MARGO: Why?

COUNT: Because a little birdie with the right tools, a lot of patience and a *very* specific skillset learned that they can feed cash right into the palm of your hand without paying a *cent*.

MARGO: Mhm. And where is this bird now?

COUNT: About to take flight for the first time in a decade.

(COUNT pulls out his LIGHTER, there is a flicking sound)

MARGO: You’re going to set the machine on fire?

COUNT: This is more than just a lighter, dear. Observe.

(A button is pressed, there are several clicks in rapid succession as a monkey-paw-esque pronged instrument emerges from the side of the lighter)

COUNT: *This* is the little device that put an entire line of slot machines out of business.

MARGO: Thought you said your skillset’s smoking.

COUNT: I'm multifaceted, darling.

(CASINO MACHINE turns on)

AUTOMATED VOICE (JACKPOT): Welcome to Luck of The Moirai!

(A little, eight bit jingle plays, ending in a minor suspended sound)

CLOTHO: Do you have what it takes to take fate into your own hands?

LACHESIS: I see a jackpot in your future!

ATROPOS: $20!

MARGO: Charming. So have you just forgotten we were attacked by an alien a moment ago?

COUNT: You've been quipping as much as I have, darl.

MARGO: Not talking about your tone. I mean the fact that instead of trying to get out of the clearly compromised casino you're hunched over a slots machine like an eighty-year-old.

COUNT: Well, I-

(Attempting to phrase correctly)

COUNT: You-

(Beat)

Follow my logic here.

MARGO: I'm listening.

COUNT: So if the world's ending-

MARGO: Which it has-

COUNT: And society has collapsed-

MARGO: Which it will- probably-

COUNT: And the concept of money implodes and has no more intrinsic value anymore because all of these bills and coins are just social constructs that provide no genuine value to someone just trying to eat, sleep and survive?

MARGO: Exactly. So stop fisting the machine and keep walking.

COUNT: Ah- I'm not finished. That's only the first motion of the end of the world. Because after the weak are culled and the fit have all survived et al et al, there will be trading camps, and eventually, stores. And what will they need then?

MARGO: …no, that’s not- they end up trading goods for other goods. It becomes a bartering society.

COUNT: But people are lazy, Margo. Maybe on a small scale you can trade a tin of tomatoes for a back rub, but how will everyone agree that food is worth the same as, say bullets? Eventually, they'll look for a way to streamline bartering with, say, a measurement of value? And then badda-bingo badda-boomo- look what exists again. Moolah.

(A click. A loud jingle, an irritating arpeggio.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (JACKPOT): JACKPOT!

COUNT: See, Mags? Not just a pretty face.

(Pause)

MARGO: Go fuck yourself.

COUNT: Later, darling.

MARGO: This plan is very thought out. You been waiting on the world to end too?

COUNT: I’m good at improvising. Anyway, to finish my point, when those little alien monsters are all wiped out and life goes back to normal, *I* will be a couple hundred thousand up in these bad boys-

(Sound of a receipt printing)

COUNT: The fuck?

MARGO: So much for a couple hundred thousand.

COUNT: "To cash in your prize of $200,000, please give this slip to a rewards table to have the money transferred to a bank account"- what happened to the bills?

MARGO: Can't you just cash it in to your bank?

COUNT: What are you talking about? Where's the satisfaction in that? The weight of paper and metal in your hand? The thrill of the hunt?

MARGO: You can still- (take out the money once you've banked it-)

(In synchrony with COUNT)

MARGO: You don't have a bank account.

COUNT: I don't have a bank account.

MARGO: (Smiling) You sure you haven't been prepping for an apocalypse?

COUNT: It's called being old fashioned. And, well, evading tax-

MARGO: Mhm.

COUNT: There's probably a few that aren't as modern, there's what- one-two- at least three hundred machines in here. Some will still have good old-fashioned coin in them.

MARGO: You're not that stupid, Count. They're all the same. Let's go.

COUNT: Can’t knock it until you’ve tried it.

MARGO: You just tried it. You gonna keep shuffling your feet or haul your ass to the car park with me?

COUNT: Margo-

(Pause)

COUNT: Look, if you want to keep on with your little renegade journey I can't stop you. But frankly, I-

COUNT: This is a casino. I'm a grifter. Ain’t no monsters going to siege a place like this. And I have enough places to hide, even if it gets weird.

MARGO: So you’re staying here?

COUNT: Mhm.

MARGO: I-

(Beat)

MARGO: Nah, that's about all the effort I'm willing to put in. Have a good one, man.

COUNT: You too.

MARGO: (Pregnant Pause) (Sighs)

(MARGO leaves, and walks through the crowds of machines, leaving COUNT alone)

(COUNT sighs. Starts rattling again)

(A little, eight bit jingle plays, ending in a minor suspended sound)

AUTOMATED VOICE (JACKPOT): Welcome to Luck of the Morai!

CLOTHO: Do you have what it takes to take fate into your own hands?

LACHESIS: I see a jackpot in your future!

ATROPOS: $400!

(Slight rattling continues in silence for a while)

WAITER: Drink, Sir?

(COUNT yelps. The rattling cuts off abruptly.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (JACKPOT): Aw, well that’s too bad. Better luck next time!

COUNT: Jesus, kid, a little heads up next time.

WAITER: I did, Sir. I said "Drink, Sir?"

COUNT: Well- yes. Anyway- look kid- I got my credit card stuck inside the machine, and I was just tryna get it back out, you know how it is with these new- these new slots, all wires and cogs and-

WAITER: It’s okay, sir. I don't care that you were cheating.

COUNT: Whoa kid, don't say it so loud-

WAITER: There's nobody at the rewards table to cash it in to, sir. Everyone's gone.

COUNT: Oh.

(A pause)

COUNT: You're not.

WAITER: You're not either, Sir.

COUNT: Well, I didn't know I was alone. Where's everyone gone?

(The rattling sounds start up again)

WAITER: There was an evacuation notice about fifteen minutes ago from Hera. She told everyone to make their way to the evacuation shelter downtown. Did you not hear it?

COUNT: Mmph, something about an elevator. Well how come you're still slogging drinks around an empty casino?

WAITER: Same reason you're digging through slot machines, Sir.

COUNT: What, money?

WAITER: No sir, routine.

(Pause)

COUNT (Warmly-ish): I'll get a Chicago Fizz with a shot of vodka mixed in and an orange juice, if that's alright with you, kid.

WAITER: Of course, sir.

COUNT: And just Count is fine.

WAITER (Lightly Flustered): Oh- I apologise, Count. I didn't realise we had- royalty with us today-

COUNT: (Laughs) You're good, kid. It's just a nickname. Dad gave it to me when I was younger.

(Beat)

COUNT: Anyway, drink. There might be a 200-thousand-dollar tip with your name on it if you're fast enough.

WAITER: Of course, Count.

(The Waiter leaves)

(COUNT hums lightly to himself.)

(Intercom Blares)

HERA: Good Day, Mortals. I apologise for- the early transmission, but- Hermes did another fly around th-
(Beat)
I'm not doing the voice right now. It feels insensitive, I- To anyone still in The Atheneum Casino, do not leave the building. I- oh my god I- Something’s wrong with the sun and- nobody should leave. People are, transforming, and, I don't know I don't- We have, uh, there's a group of staff on the Tartarus- the basement floor, and we're probably going to stay down here until we hear about what the hell is going on, but there's a lot of these things in the Casino and-
(a phone rings)
Hello? Yes, this is the Atheneum, I- On what floor? There's (Back onto microphone, urgent)
Anyone on the higher floors of the building-

(A gentle creaking sound)

There is- a- something is coming out of the sky it's- you *have* to get to lower ground NOW! It's- - Good God- I’ve never seen anything like-

(The speakers cut off as a loud cracking sound is heard, like a hand crunching down on a rice crispy)
(The creaking of foundations and steel as the entire bottom of the building, below Count, begins to move)

COUNT: What the fuck-

(A scream of metal as suddenly COUNT is airbourne, wind begins flapping as slot machines begin sliding off the edge as the building is slowly lifted into the air. Crumbling and destruction of the building above.

COUNT: What the fuck is-

WAITER (Distantly): Count!

COUNT: Kid! You're gonna have to jump or we're going to smash against th-

(COUNT is hit by a slot machine and starts falling. The lever is tugged, and it begins jingling.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (JACKPOT): Welcome to Luck of The Moirai!

CLOTHO: Do you have what it takes to take fate into your own hands?

LACHESIS: I see a jackpot in your future!

ATROPOS: $2,000,000!

(COUNT, winded, gasps for air. The casino machine flies away and shatters against another machine, as COUNT is in freefall, the echoing building far above them.)

COUNT (Terrified): No! I don-

(COUNT hits water like a bellyflop, all sound is muted, as he sinks. More objects hit the water around him.)

(Breathing time)

COUNT (Internally): You should get up.

COUNT: Mmph. Cosy here.

COUNT: You're lying too, and bad at it. Your back hurts, your leg is numb, you hit your head at least five times, there's water in your mouth and nose, and the chlorine is hurting your eyes.
And you're forty five wearing bathrobes and spending your life making money in casinos to spend on more bathrobes and rides to go to more casinos.

COUNT: What would you do any differently?

(Pause. Distant crashing, occasional objects hit the water)

COUNT: We landed in water. Do you know how lucky that is?

COUNT: I'm a gambler. Gotta get lucky sometimes.

COUNT: Where even are we? Was there a swimming pool?

COUNT: Does it matter? When was the last time you paid attention to anything? 'ts not living if you never really give a shit.

(Pause)

COUNT: I don't really want to die here, right?

COUNT: Beats me.

COUNT (Slightly more panicked): I *don’t* actually want to die, right??

COUNT: Mh? do something about it then, dickhead.

(COUNT groans, and is yanked, being pulled to the surface)

COUNT: Looks like someone beat you to it. Here’s to a second chance, or something.

COUNT: Back to the dry world, bucko.

(COUNT resubmerges gasping for air.)

COUNT: Who was that- you-

(COUNT sees WAITER)

COUNT: Kid, you- you saved-

(COUNT screams)

COUNT: What's wrong with your face?

(WAITERS left eye has bulged outwards, and leaks black fluid. Their mouth is filling with large lumps, that are growing into little swaying tentacles.)

OTHER-WAITER: It's the sun, COUNT.

COUNT: Huh?

OTHER-WAITER: Look at the sun. It’s so beautiful.

COUNT: The s-

(COUNT turns up to look, but is grabbed and held to face the ground by a hand)

MARGO: Don't you fucking dare or I'm going put a bullet in your fucking head.

COUNT: Wh- Why?

MARGO: Look at the boy.

(WAITER begins sobbing, and their sobs begin convulsing into strained gasps, before becoming a different kind of gasp, painful and exerted. A drawn out, slurping, slick sound.)

COUNT: What's happening to him?

MARGO: I don't know. But whatever's come out the sun is turning people into-

(WAITER gasps)

MARGO: …that.

(MARGO pulls out a handgun)

COUNT: Wait!

MARGO: Count. It’ll try and kill us otherwise.

(A shot, the OTHER WAITER gasps. MARGO fires six more times. The OTHER WAITER sighs, and falls back into the water.)

MARGO: The thing in the sky. It pulled the entire top of the casino off. It- (As if reminding a child) Don't look up- It ripped it

apart. Some kind of- tentacle or something. We need to move before some debris smashes one of our skulls in.

(COUNT pulls himself out the water. They walk in silence, for a couple moments, COUNT's wet feet plapping against the marble floor.)

COUNT: I didn't know it was this bad.

MARGO: Me neither. But I'm still taking the apology. There's a stairwell here. It probably won't take another chunk out the building. It's only twenty floors from the bottom here.

COUNT: Where…

(A large door echoes open. The sounds of outside become heavily reverbed as they enter and shut the door.)

MARGO: The spa floors.

(They begin walking down iron stairs, loud clunking as they walk.)

MARGO: Alright.

(MARGO stops walking.)

MARGO: I'm heading down to the bottom floor. You should go through this door here. Find somewhere else.

(Beat)

COUNT (Confused): What?

MARGO (Snappily): What?

COUNT: I-

(Pause)

COUNT: I need to go with you. I don't think I'll survive on my own.

MARGO: No, you won't.

(A pause)

MARGO: But I don’t need you and you know it.

COUNT: But-

MARGO: (Slowly escalating in anger) But what? In case I need to open a vending machine? Give a monster a cigarette? For all your talk of skillsets Count, you're particularly- (fucking useless)

COUNT: It’s my dad. He works at- (Resets) My father is an esteemed astrophysicist at the International Institution of Interstellar travel.

MARGO: The ones who launched that ship, the,(trying to remember)- The Count-

(A pause)

COUNT: The Count Marigois. The one on route to Europa, yes.

(A pause)

MARGO: You- (lying piece of shit)

COUNT: I know it sounds. I know given the circumstances it sounds like I'm trying to bullshit you but I swear on his life I am dead serious. His name is William Rettentamber, and he's been on the official board of directors since 1983. I grew up with him in our home town of Fallon. He's slightly taller than me, has shaggy grey hair and his wedding ring has the coordinates to a star he named after my mother engraved on it.
And- and he- and you can't take the risk that I'm lying, either. You- you were right about all of this, weren't you? You- you knew about this *thing* in the sun, and you might be the only one that still knows about its origins and- you might be the only person who has evidence that we knew about that thing, and -that information is important. And I swear on my life I can get you into one of their compounds and get the knowledge you know to someone higher up. And, if I die and down the line you die alone in some random survivor camp where everyone's eyes are glued to the floor trying not to stare at this thing in the sky and you rot in some dusty warehouse and this information dies with you, we- that's a loss isn't it? For all of us. When you have the chance to make a difference. I can-
I can give you that chance, Margo.

(A long pause)

MARGO (Emotionally, but still angry): Where's their nearest site?

COUNT: North Nevada, about a nine hour drive to the northeast.

MARGO: And you swear you can get me in?

COUNT: I promise on my life.

(A pause)

MARGO: Come on.

(MARGO opens the door)

COUNT: I thought you said you were going down-

MARGO: I talked to someone before you got here. They said the lower stairwells were clogged with those things.

(Pause)

MARGO: You don't have a weapon. I couldn't send you down into them alone.

(Pause)

COUNT: Alright.

MARGO: Come on.

(COUNT follows MARGO through the door. It SLAMS behind them.)

II

(A more distant, reverbed song, slightly aquatic and echoed.)

AUTOMATED VOICE (POSIDEON): Welcome to Poseidon's Springs. Please do not run on the wet surfaces.

COUNT: It's so dark. – Parallel to Part One.

MARGO: I think most the power grid is busted at this point. Just emergency lights.

COUNT: Why make them red? It's,, ominous

MARGO: (I don't know sound, again) Come on, we can take these staircases down.

(Sounds of descending.)

MARGO: Alright. If you're the kid of a well-known superscientist, why-

COUNT: Why am I fourty years old and mooching around casinos?

MARGO: Exactly.

COUNT: I was at college before, (in gesturing to self) this. Probably three decades ago now. I adored space. Maybe because of my dad, maybe he just got lucky. Full on spaceship themed beds, glow in the dark stars on the ceiling, the whole thing. My mother spent a couple hundred bucks on a spacesuit costume for Halloween and I wore it every year until I was fourteen. She said it was the perfect investment she'd make because I'd never lose interest.

(As they walk, there are distant blaring alarms. The sounds of running water, bubbling pools, and showers spraying water spray as they walk.)

COUNT: Majored in Astrophysics. Was gonna be just like my dad, work in the same labs, working on the same equations to get the same ships out into the same galaxies, but…
Meh.

MARGO: Meh…?

COUNT: I couldn't really tell you. Maybe I drunk too much. Maybe I gambled too much, maybe there was just something wrong in my head, but either way I just. Stopped caring? One day I had four papers due the next week and then the next day I had stopped giving a shit. Left college to go spend the weekend in a casino downtown. Never came back. Didn't pick up any of my stuff from my flat. Just, started again.

MARGO: You just ditched your family?

COUNT: My mom turned my back on me after a couple years- she and my dad came out to find me when I was twenty. I was a real scumbag to them. She hasn't talked to me since. But my dad- Every year, hes found where I'm staying and mailed me his current phone number and a letter inviting me to Thanksgiving. I've never been.

MARGO: You sound remorseful.

COUNT: Cause I am.

MARGO: Then talk to them again.

COUNT: It's too late, isn't it? I feel bad, but I'm not going to my parents with a half assed apology knowing I'm going to go straight back to gambling and doing fuck all with my life. Better to just, not talk to them at that point.

MARGO: End of the world's a good enough excuse.

COUNT: Guess so. You have any family you're scared for?

MARGO: Not really. I was the fifth of ten siblings. Stopped talking to most of them when I was a teenager. My older brother's alright though, still talk to him sometimes.

(Pause)

MARGO: He'll probably be fine.

(Another pause)

MARGO: I- I don't mean to sound ungrateful to them but- You know? In basically every sense, I came from and was nothing. The expectation from my family wasn't to pursue an education or anything bigger but to start working night shifts at some fast food joint to keep our family alive. I- I don't knock them or anything, it wouldn't have been fair to have expected more from them but, it was as if the world around us had already deemed us placeholders and nothing else. We would take up space, and then die, and that was our life lived, and nobody would have assumed or asked anything different, because they're also taking up space and dying. I hated that.
But what was I going to do? Be some motivational story about some kid who comes from nothing getting into an Ivy League somewhere to make six figures in business? God no. I didn't want to rise from discarded scrap to a perfectly functioning part in some machine somewhere, I wanted to be the spanner that gets stuck in the cogs, causing everything to break apart, blow up or whatever.
And what if only now I get to do something with my life, only once everything's fucking destroyed? Is it even a victory then? Where's the man I'm sticking it to if not transformed into some braindead tentacle *thing*?

COUNT: Margo.

MARGO: Hm?

COUNT: I'm not good at giving wisdom. But I'm good at hindsight, and I stopped fighting the moment things got difficult. You can't do the same.

MARGO: …Okay-

COUNT: It’d have been rude to have cut you off. But- but there’s a lot of those things. We’re being surrounded.

(Collective slithering sound. OTHERS surround the two. COUNT's breathing intensifies, moves to his POV. His heart starts beating faster, blood pounding in his ears.)

MARGO: Shit,, I didn't realise there were so many. Okay, Count, I'm going to fire several shots at them. Then you’re going to need to (bait them by running)

(COUNT breaks into a sprint)

MARGO: Count, what are you- shit!

(MARGO fires a shot, the creatures start screaming and jumping at the pair. MARGO starts running)

COUNT (Visibly completely terrified): Shit, shit,

MARGO: Count! What the fuck are you doing!

COUNT (Panicked): (Mostly Unintelligible, Something about not dying, scared shitless)

MARGO: Count! I need you to focus, don't freak out on me- you fucking-

(One of the creatures grabs MARGO's foot, they fall and hit the ground. They turn and fire several shots)

(COUNT finds a door and opens it, it squeaks as it opens. There is an OTHER on his heels)

MARGO: Count, hold the door, I'm-

(COUNT slams the door shut. A moment later, MARGO appears on the other side, muffled)

MARGO: Open the door!

COUNT (Hysterical): I'm sorry!

MARGO: Count! Let me in!

(A creature slams against the door. MARGO fires several shots)

(MARGO runs, getting quieter as they talk)

MARGO: You fucking piece of shit! I fucking save you and you're so self-obsessed you'd protect your own worthless life over being grateful to someone else for one moment of your fucking life! I swear to god Count, (I'll fucking kill you myself if I get the chance-)

(MARGO's voice fades away, alongside gunshots and various OTHERs following them.)

(COUNT is left sobbing. OTHER's hit their head against the door every now and then, groaning. COUNT is not alone. COUNT's breathing steadies.)

COUNT: It's so hot…

(Pause)

Oh. I locked myself in a sauna. Fucking figures.

AUTOMATED VOICE (SAUNA): This is an automated response system to the failure of the main power grid within the Atheneum Hotel. If by any chance the electromagnetic lock on the sauna door has failed, and you are trapped within this unit, please use the emergency phone provided to call the Front Desk on 111, or, in case of desperate assistance, please call 911 by first dialing the hash key to call an external number.

(COUNT walks over to the phone, sound of it coming off the wall. COUNT presses several buttons, clearly more than 3 or 4, and waits for it to start dialing.)

(A ringing)

(More ringing)

COUNT: (Whispered) Please.

(Eventually, someone picks up.)

WILLIAM: Hello?

(A pause)

WILLIAM: Hello?

COUNT: Hi, Will.

(A pause)

WILLIAM: Count, is that you?

COUNT: (Citing a quote) Over and out, dad.

(WILLIAM laughs)

WILLIAM: You're alive. I was terrified you wouldn't make it.

COUNT: There's still time for me to die.

WILLIAM: (Dismissive sound) There's always another moment to get killed. But you're a Rettentamber, and they don't get us down that easily, eh? | Where are you right now? Are you safe?

COUNT: The Atheneum. Vegas. And (Beat) I'm sorry.

(A pause)

COUNT: I'm sorry. For being so useless. For dropping out of college. For only living for myself. I- don't know why, and I wish I had a good explanation. I just- stopped caring. And I've never found a way to start again.
I've never tried, either. Not really. And I'm sorry for wasting all those years of your time you spent hoping I'd become something.

(A pause)

COUNT: And I fucked up badly this time. There's someone out there, with ambition, and actual aspiration, and still has a chance to do something with their god forsaken life, and it's more than I'll ever do, and despite that I'm still valuing my life over theirs because- because- I don't even know. I'm selfish, and I still don't give a shit if I live, or if I die or-

WILLIAM: Count (2nd count?)

COUNT: I need to get them to the Northern Nevada Spacesite. I promised them that much. I owe them that much. I- this isn't me believing I need a redemption, god no i- just- but if I help someone else, who genuinely, *actually*, wants to do something with their life. Do you think that could be enough? For now?

(A LONG pause)

WILLIAM (Tearily): It hurts to hear you talk like this.

(Pause)

Do you remember Mt. Hamilton? When we were celebrating you getting into college, and drove out to that little site in Cali on the top of the hills with those- strange- little black birds we kept seeing? And you were going to college and I was admitted onto the board for the Europa project, and it felt like nothing could have held us down, and we sat with your telescope and picked out your favourite

stars, and I pointed out Europa and said, we'll be there someday, and then, and you said to me - and I've never forgotten it, Count - You stretched up on your legs and reached out across the stars and said

"One day, I am going to take the sun."

I've never stopped seeing that young man, Count. It's still you. You can't kill a fire like that easily.

Whatever this world is becoming, it's… so different, Count. But it doesn't have to be an ending, you could- we could-

Start again. Maybe.

But if all you can do for now is keep your head off the ground, then keep your head off the ground.

But you have to promise me you'll keep fighting.

(Pause)

COUNT: Okay.

WILLIAM: Say it.

COUNT: I promise. I'll keep fighting.

WILLIAM: Atta, Count. | Space royalty, you said. It would be the next big thing. It's not too late to see that a reality.

COUNT: Thank you.

WILLIAM: Of course, Count. I'm in a bunker below the Nevada Site. There's a couple men stationed up top, I'll let them know to keep an eye out for my son.

COUNT: Of course. I- I'll see you soon, dad.

WILLIAM: See you soon, spacebug. And don't look at the sun! We're still not fully sure what's happening, but I'd like to see my kid without any extra tentacles!

COUNT: I love you.

WILLIAM: I love you too, spacebug.

(COUNT hangs up. The steamy room is quiet except for the sound of gentle slamming against the door.)

Count hits himself?

COUNT: Alright. Get out of this sauna, find Margo, apologise, get a car out of here, and drive all the way across Nevada without ever once looking at the sun.

(Pause)

We'll start with getting out of the sauna.

(COUNT lights a cigarette. The deep rumbling synths of the spa continue)

COUNT: I knocked one of these things out a window. Doubt I can do it to all five outside. Not enough trolleys. Or windows. Drowning them would take too long. Don't know if they can actually breathe. Gonna have to fight. But with what?

(COUNT sprays mint breath spray in his mouth. Fiddles with his lighter, turning it on and off. Sprays the mint.)

COUNT: Oh. Hm.

(The door slams open. A muted melody, Cops and Robbers style)

(COUNT kicks open the door, the five OTHER's outside hiss and stagger back.)

COUNT: Heya, squid. I've done some thinking, and I've realised that we're quite alike. You were all people right? We all ended up here, in this crummy casino during off season, an-

(One of the OTHER's hisses and jumps at COUNT)

COUNT: Woah! I'll cut the pleasantries, then.

(Sound of a lighter. An instrument comes in)

COUNT: Fire.

(Sound of mint bottle being sprayed. (An second instrument comes in)

COUNT: Aerosol. You connected the dots yet?

(A pause. One of the creatures starts charging at COUNT)

COUNT: No? Shame.

(The spray is sprayed into the lighter. A huge flame spurts out, basking the OTHER in flame. It screeches. The song begins in full.)

COUNT: Impromptu pyrotechnics weren’t what I had in mind when I brought this lighter- but that’s my real skillset, isn’t it?

(The OTHER continues screeching. Count shakes the bottle)

COUNT: Improvisation!

(Two OTHERS charge at COUNT. He sprays them both, they stagger backwards.)

COUNT: I've been thinking, about the easiest way to get out of here.

(COUNT kicks open a door, there are several more OTHER's in here. They hiss.)

COUNT: And first I'm gonna need more fire. So if I take the cap off of…

(Sound of fiddling. The cap comes off the top of the lighter.)

COUNT: There. No safety cover on the lighter, no limit to the size of the flame- I think. Who's first?

(Distant sounds of OTHERs running, they burst open the door, and start pouring towards COUNT.)

COUNT: Enthusiastic, are we? One at a time, please!

(COUNT holds down the spray, and a continues, large burst of flame flies out, over the OTHER's, who screech, and start spasming as COUNT walks through them. The song crescendos for a moment.

COUNT (Laughing): I should NOT have been putting this spray in my mouth!

(The fire and screeching dies down. COUNT steps over the bodies. Enters a changing room. COUNT gasps. The music dies down to a slower pace.)

COUNT: Damn. Out of mint spray. Glad these ones don't seem to mind.

(A squeak from one of the OTHER's as COUNT steps on it.)

COUNT: Changing room. Nothing too interesting here, but-

(COUNT gasps)

COUNT: A new robe!

(COUNT dons the bathrobe)

COUNT: So much better. Shame it's an actual bathrobe.

(COUNT lets out a short huff)

COUNT: There's an emergency exit just through this hall. I don't want to go without a weapon, though. Is there anything left? Any guns, or…

AUTOMATED VOICE (FIRE): Smoke detected. Fire Extinguishers are highlighted with bright green lights.

COUNT: Bongo.

(CUT to COUNT opening another door, several types of screech and noise from OTHER's in the room. The A-part of the song repeats one more time.)

(COUNT hits one over the head with a fire extinguisher. It squelches in a particularly unpleasant way.)

COUNT: One.

(Another grapples COUNT. COUNT sprays it with fire extinguisher foam, as it staggers backwards. COUNT socks it in the stomach.)

COUNT: Another Sauna! Perfect.

(COUNT opens the door, pushes the creature in with the foam, and slams the door.)

COUNT: Two.

(Two screech at COUNT. COUNT sprays them both with foam, before charging, knocking them both backwards into a body of water, with two large splashes.

COUNT: Three, and Four. Can these things swim?

(The two OTHER's resurface, kicking and yelping.)

COUNT: Nope, they cannot.

(COUNT turns and walks, humming along to the melody.)

COUNT: And there's the emergency exit!

(A hiss)

COUNT: And there's the gatekeeper.

(A pause, the music stays suspended)

COUNT: Alright, look here, Squid.
I'm out of cigs.
I'm out of breath spray, lighter fluid, and fire extinguisher foam.
I've been hit with a slot machine, drowned, and-
Well actually I've gotten through surprisingly unscathed, all things considered.

And if you're the last thing between me, and getting that kid out of here safe, then on my fucking life I will tear you apart with my bare hands. So get out the way, or-

(A beep from COUNT's left)

COUNT: Wait shit- that's not the emergency exit.

(COUNT starts running, the OTHER follows)

COUNT: Shit, shit-

(COUNT grabs open the door, slams it behind himself. The OTHER squelches, as the door slams, screaming and slamming slightly.)

(COUNT gasps for air, before laughing.)

COUNT: You hear that, Sun-Beast? Count Rittentamber isn't fucking finished yet! I am going to live!

(Continues breathing)

COUNT: Heh. I wish someone heard that.

(COUNT is descending stairs. It is silent, save for the reverb of his feet.)

COUNT: Margo said Tartarus Level. If I just make it down- What does that say-

(COUNT reads something on a wall, mumbling as he reads)

COUNT: 19 flights of stairs. I'll get there.

(COUNT continues walking. The intercom blares to life, one last time.)

HERA: Hello.

(A pause)

I'm not sure if this thing still works. Hell, I'm not sure if there's anyone still alive in the Casino. The cameras are all down but- this thing runs on an emergency power grid just in case, well, this happens.
The basement is overrun. Turns out the things can understand language, still. They all swarmed us as soon as I broadcast my last message. Because of course they can. I-
It might just be me now.
There's an access tunnel at the very bottom of the basement. Goes into the sewage system below Vegas. I'm going there. If I truly am the last living- well, *human* inhabitant of the Atheneum Resort, then I hope all the tentacle things will chase me down. I hope it gives anyone else here a good chance at getting out.
I took this job because I was a failed actor. I starred in a B-list movie once, and the rush I got was unlike anything I've felt in my life. Sadly, critics didn't agree, and my career ended like that. Pretending to be a Greek Goddess in a Casino full of low-life's felt like a fitting end, in a way.
What happens now?
My name is Tasha Ndiachesvkaya. I was alive. Twenty four hours from now, I will still be alive.
I hope the same for anyone still out there.
This is Hera, signing off for the very last time. And I would like to remind all patrons of the Atheneum Hotel about the last call for our Ford Chariot giveaway. The monster truck of the Gods. The Chariot is held in the main reception. Just take a raffle ticket

from your nearest gift shop to enter. Goodnight, Athenians. And Good Luck.
(A beeping sound. The transmission cuts off.)

(COUNT has stopped walking)

COUNT: Ground floor. No point going any deeper I guess, huh. Good on ya, Tasha. Here’s to a second chance. For all of us.

(COUNT opens the door into a back room. There is a rattling, spinning sound.)

COUNT: I'll be damned.

AUTOMATED VOICE (APOLLO): Heya, Boys and Girls and Gods! Here to enter the Ford Chariot raffle? Just input two dollars via cash or card to receive a ticket!

COUNT: One last hurrah, eh?

(Flicking sounds, as COUNT opens the lighter and extends the Monkey Paw.)

COUNT: Let's see if this old bird can learn a few new tricks.

(Fade out)

(Footsteps. The gentle swaying of a chandelier. Wind can be heard, pushing through a shattered window. A rattling sound.)

ELPIS: Incorrect authorisation. Please try again.

MARGO: Look, you fucking robot. You are a car. If you don't drive, then-

(Footsteps continue)

MARGO: Who's there? Take another step and I'll blow your head off.

COUNT: It's me.

(MARGO fires a shot)

COUNT: Shit- I didn't take another step!

MARGO: I'm making an exception for you. Get out of my fucking sight before I fix my aim.

COUNT: Margo, I'm sorry-

MARGO: What do you think this is? Some cutesy little story where you apologise and then it's all good again? Count- (I want you dead.)

COUNT: I want to make things better-

MARGO: Great! I'm glad for you! But don't do that around me! I'm finished travelling with someone I can't trust, do you understand? It's a privilege for someone to give you a second chance and forgive you, and I'm not giving you it. So piss off.

ELPIS: Incorrect Authorisation.

MARGO: Shut up!

COUNT: Margo, I c-

MARGO: I don't need your-

(As COUNT starts talking, a single, electronic beat begins)

COUNT: You don't need my help! You've gotten through a lifetime of shit without me, and you will continue to do so without me! I don't want to keep hanging off you like a tumour, but-
You have a goal, Margo! A genuine actual reason to live you- You have a surefire way to make the world better, and help out anyone still alive on this planet. And I know your success won't rub off on me if I help you, but I'm so sick and tired of living for myself, and if I can once, *just* once help out someone else, then so help me sun-beast in the fucking sky, I am going to do so, and-

(Rustling sound)

I have 300 lottery tickets in my right hand, and one of them will have the correct authorisation code to activate this car to get you out of here. I don't want you to forgive me. I just want to get you out of here.

(A beat)

MARGO: Where did you get those?

COUNT: Gift shop.

(A bang)

COUNT: Is that chandelier? What's happening?

MARGO: It's from behind the double doors - the ballroom is back there.

COUNT: That sounds *big*, we need to move-

MARGO: Just get throw me the lottery tickets and-

(The double doors burst open, and a huge, amorphous black form stumbles in. It is made of many smaller OTHERs, congealed together. They consist of smaller parts of the larger being, some beginning to melt into each other.)

COUNT: Where the fuck did that come from-

(Various Others make groaning sounds)

MARGO: It's made from the- human- squids. They’re all congealed together like- Is this what's going to happen to everyone?

(The beast lets out a loud screech. It rattles the windows and chandelier.)

COUNT: Margo, I'll distract it-

MARGO: No, you won't!

COUNT: But-

MARGO: If you want to be self-sacrificial, be my guest, but as it stands you *still* don't have a gun, so get down here and get this car working or else-

(The creature screeches again. Margo shouts and fires the shotgun.)

MARGO: Die, you fucking-

(The creature lets out a yelp. It doesn't really react.)

MARGO: Shit.

COUNT: Run!

(It lunges at MARGO, who starts running, firing back at the creature.)

COUNT: Okay. Okay. Okay. Think. Margo's distracting the big thing. Margo *will* die if you don't help them. I won't have enough time to get through all of these lottery tickets in the time it takes for that thing to rip her apart. Then we both die. So then I have to distr-

MARGO: Count! Do something! (Shot)

COUNT: I'm out of fire, don't have a gun, the only thing between me and the car is a chandelier and about a thirty feet drop, and-

(Shot)

COUNT: Margo! Keep it below the chandelier!

MARGO: How do you suggest I do that, genius?

(COUNT makes a running jump, and hits the side of the chandelier, it makes a loud wind chime scream, as it swings from side to side)

(COUNT grunts)

COUNT: Find light- find the power for this chandelier! It'll be distracted by the light!

(COUNT climbs onto the chandelier, and walks across it, as it swings and spins, the whooshing of momentum as he walks and makes light grunts.)

COUNT (Quietly): Alright.

(Snapping of a lighter, it extends into the monkey paw.)

COUNT: Don't fail me now.

MARGO: This better- fucking- work-

(Distant sound of light switches being pushed, heavy – big lever. The chandelier roars to life, the hum of electricity below COUNT's feet.)

MARGO: Lights on! The thing is- no fucking way.

(The creature makes a curious gurgle, and begins stumbling over.)

MARGO: (Laughs) Dumbass monster. Get down here, Count- Count?

(COUNT is fiddling with the chain of the chandelier)

COUNT: Just- a moment-

MARGO: Count! What the fuck are you doing? Get down!

COUNT: Buying us time! If I can just-

MARGO: No! The power, genius! If you break the chandelier while the power is live then-

(A snap, as the chandelier begins falling. The shooting of electricial fire, as the chandelier collides with mushy flesh, the shattering of glass, and a scream as the chandelier hits the ground.)

COUNT: Catch me, catch me-

(COUNT falls and is barely caught by MARGO)

COUNT: Oh! You actually did, I-

MARGO: That move warranted it. Come on, tickets.

(COUNT ruffles for the tickets, and hands them to MARGO)

COUNT: Here.

MARGO: Cheers.

(MARGO starts running to the car. The creature writhes and screams in the background.)

COUNT: Margo- (in beginning to become sentimental and say goodbye)

MARGO (Further away): Count? Count!

COUNT: Wh- Yes?

MARGO: Fuck are you just standing there for? Come on!

COUNT: But-

MARGO: I'm not a sadist, Count, I'm not leaving you alone with this thing. Get in!

COUNT: Oh- Okay!

(COUNT runs over, opens the car door, and shuts the door behind him. The rest of the sound is muted.)

ELPISVOICE: Please enter the correct authorisation.

(MARGO unwraps paper.)

MARGO: So you're saying it's one of these codes?

COUNT: Has to be. Or one of those squid things has the right code and this is all pointless.

MARGO: You're a gambler, aren't you? Isn’t it all about chance, anyway?

COUNT: Heh. Guess so. But I prefer rigged ga-

MARGO: Okay shut up. It's this bunch of symbols on the ticket here, right?

COUNT: I think so.

MARGO: Alright. GX752.

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: Incorrect authorisation.

MARGO: DV323.

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: Incorrect au-

MARGO: TR193.

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: Incorrect authorisation.

COUNT (looking over his shoulder): I think that things trying to get up-

MARGO: Alright. Here.

(MARGO shoves a bunch of tickets into COUNT's hands)

MARGO: You read too. RW231.

(Over the background of the two talking, the screaming creature, begins shattering glass, and regaining strength, letting out screeches and shaking the heavy chains of the chandelier.)

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: I-

COUNT: FA745.

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: Incorr-

MARGO: YP342.

(The car makes a light blare)

ELPIS: Inc-

COUNT: WC599.

(Blare)

MARGO: XR769.

(Blare)

COUNT: AA224.

(Blare)

(The creature is up. Its begins trudging towards the car)

MARGO: WP456.

(Blare)

(At the same time as COUNT says)

COUNT: It's back up.

COUNT: QR462.

(Blare)

(As the same time MARGO says)

MARGO: So read faster, asshole. RT789.

(Blare)

COUNT: DS2-

(The creature slams a tentacle against the side of the car)

COUNT (Yelped): 98!

(Blare)

MARGO: SD48T!

(Blare)

(The hammering gets stronger)

COUNT: AL113!

(Blare)

MARGO: PW278!

(Blare)

COUNT: PX451!

(A ding)

ELPIS: Permission Granted. Good Evening. Please record your name after the beep.

MARGO: Yes!

COUNT: Margo- look ou-

(The shattering of glass on MARGO's side of the car. They scream as they are picked up and dragged through the window)

COUNT: Margo!

ELPIS: Very well. Good evening, “Yes Margo Lookou Margo.”

COUNT: Shit!

ELPIS: Threat detected at the rear of the car. Assessing threat level.

(Scanning sound)

ELPIS: Threat level: Egregious. No human detected in driver's seat. Activating autopilot.

(Click, and light hissing sound.)

COUNT: Margo!

(COUNT tries to open the passenger side door. The door does not open.)

ELPIS: Safety lock activated for the protection of the passengers. Activating escape protocols.

(The engine lights up, and begins rumbling.)

COUNT: What's with this car-

(The car begins driving)

COUNT: Hey! Where are you going!

ELPIS: Activating Escape Protocol. Egregious threat detected behind the vehicle. Retreating to ensure safety of passengers.

COUNT: Wh- no. We're missing someone! Go back, go back!

ELPIS: Unable to manoeuvre a U-Turn while autopilot is active.

MARGO: Count!

COUNT: Okay, uh- deactivate autopilot.

ELPIS: Human in driver's seat not detected. Autopilot override rejected.

COUNT: Fuck- okay.

(COUNT shuffles over. The screaming of the beast and MARGO gets quieter.)

COUNT: Deactivate autopilot.

ELPIS: Human driver detected. Deactivating autopilot.

(A hiss, and a click.)

COUNT: Shit okay. This car is massive. I just need to-

(COUNT hits the brake, and yanks the steering wheel. The car jerks to the right, and does a U-Turn)

ELPIS: 180 Manoeuvre of truck detected. Releasing high pressured air to assist with the movements.

(Distant popping sounds. Hissing)

COUNT: Okay. There's our target.

(COUNT hits the gas. The wheels screech, and the engine blares to life.)

ELPIS: High speeds detected. Large object detected 300 feet from truck. Collision course immanent. Activating emergency break pro-

COUNT: NO! Deactivate emergency breaks-

ELPIS: Emergency Breaks Deactivated. Collision in an estimated five seconds. Are you sure what you're doing is worth it?

COUNT: Come *on*! Margo! Grab my hand!

MARGO: Count-

ELPIS: Collision in 100 feet. 50 feet. 10 f-

(A screaming as the beast is hit with the monster truck. A huge squelching sound, as the beast is blown up. MARGO cries out)

COUNT: Got you!

(COUNT grunts, and pulls MARGO into the truck.)

COUNT: Activate Autopilot! Get us the fuck out of here!

ELPIS: Autopilot activated. Not enough space for U-Turn. Activating Emergency Reversing Manouvers. Brace for impact.

(The car skids to a halt. COUNT and MARGO both hit the front of the car, and cry out.)

ELPIS: Airbags activated. Reversing truck at high speeds.

(Poof of airbags. The truck skids back loudly, the screeching continues around the truck, as the truck reverses.)

ELPIS: Recalibrating truck.

(Screech as the truck spins)

ELPIS: Truck recalibrated. Undergoing command "get us the fuck out of here".

(The truck screams as it speeds up to high speeds. The screaming fades.)

(Broken tinkle over intercom)

ZEUS: Mortal! You are now leaving the Atheneum! Safe travels, and come back soon!

(The truck continues driving.)

(COUNT begins laughing. MARGO starts laughing. It continues for a moment.)

COUNT: Well I can't say that was any safer (than before, but)-

MARGO (Screams): The sun! Look down!

COUNT: Shit- wait, where the hell is it?

MARGO: What? Oh my god. It's gone.

ELPIS: Extreme cognitohazard detected within the inner celestial sphere of Earth. Tinting windows to prevent visual site of anomaly. Manual driving will not be available during this time, to prevent risk of exposure to cognitohazard.

(The two continue breathing)

COUNT: You were right. The sun really did hatch.

MARGO: I was right. But we already knew this.

COUNT: Heh. Who would have thought?

MARGO: Not me.

(Beat)

COUNT: Do you think it will come back? Or will it leave our solar system and just, go?

MARGO: The thing in the sun?

COUNT: If it- there!

MARGO: Don't look!

COUNT: No- it's okay through the tint- you can just see its silhouette- look!

(COUNT and MARGO look through the window, as the gentle rumble of the cars driving continues.)

MARGO: Jesus…

(Beat)

COUNT: Look at how it wriggles.

(MARGO sobs slightly)

COUNT: It must just be a baby…

MARGO (Crying): I don't understand!

COUNT: Margo?

MARGO: We- but- this shouldn't have been able to happen! This society- this world- fucking. What was the point? What the fuck were my parents and my family working for if at the end of the day that-

(MARGO slams on the glass)

Thing was just going to come out of the sun and ruin everything they were trying to live for?
What does it matter that I knew? What could I do? Nothing! What could any of us have done! It's a worm the size of the fucking sun in the *sky*! We are *useless*!

(Pause)

MARGO: I thought I wanted this, Count. Thought I'd be able to tell everyone "I-fucking-told-you-so" and I'd be revered for it. What's the point now? The world ended. Properly ended. We can't come back from no more sun.

COUNT: Margo,

(beat)

I've lived almost every day of my life for mys-

(beat)

No. I have wasted almost every day of my life because I felt too pathetic to actually live it. When you don't live for anyone- not even yourself- for that long,

(beat)

This doesn't seem too different. I just don't have to feel bad about it anymore.
Margo, you and I both survived for very different reasons. But you came out of the other side of this alive. That was today.

You still have the papers from the lab, right?

MARGO: Yeah. But-

COUNT: Then there's still a chance for something to come from them.

MARGO: (Light scoff) Then what? How do we know that (they'll even be relevant to)-

COUNT: Well that's not a problem for today. If it's all truly, genuinely hopeless, and there's no chance of anything getting better ever again, there will come a day down the line when we have to deal with that. <u>You're talking to the master of kicking the can down the road.</u>

But you try looking me in the eye and tell me you don't feel the *slightest* bit excited about what happens next.

(Pause)

(MARGO laughs slightly.)

COUNT: We're probably some of the only people in the world with the chance to make a difference right now. Isn't that exciting?

MARGO: So you're taking credit now, too?

COUNT: Might as well. I want a statue next to you when we're declared Godkings of the Apocalypse.

MARGO: Pff. Anyway, where are we going?

COUNT: Oh fuck- yes! Hey, truck. Hello?

ELPIS: Good Evening, "Yes Margo Lookou Margo".

COUNT: We should probably change that.

MARGO: I like it.

COUNT: Uh-

COUNT: (To Margo) Are we calling the car something? Do I address the car by a name???

ELPIS: My name is completely customisable and controllable by the choice of the owner of this car, however, I have come with the preset name "Elpis".

COUNT: Elvis?

MARGO: Elpis.

COUNT: Weird name. Anyway, Elp, we need to go to the Northern Nevada Spacesite. Can you get us there?

ELPIS: Calculating route to the Northern Nevada Spacesite. Estimated time to arrival: Eight hours. Set course to destination?

COUNT: Bingo.

ELPIS: Recalibrating.

(The Truck does a U-Turn violently. COUNT and MARGO cry out)

MARGO: Can't you give us more warning next time that happens?

ELPIS: Understood. Accustoming preset voice notes to user preference.

COUNT: I didn't know they made cars this fancy.

MARGO: The sun hatched and you're commenting on how fancy cars are?

COUNT: Elp, are there any radio stations still up?

ELPIS: Searching FM for available radio stations.

(Beat)

ELPIS: Searching AM for available radio stations.

(Beat)

EPLISE: One station found. Now playing.

(A guitar begins playing, as the OUTRO song starts playing)

MARGO: You think any gas stations are still open? I would destroy a shitty hot dog right now.

COUNT: Let's find out. Elp, find us the nearest gas station.

Elp: Recalibrating route… Es
timated time to arrival to gas station, half an hour. Recalibrating route, prepare for U-Turn.

COUNT: Come on.
(In sync with)
MARGO: Fucks sake- no, just take us towards-

(The truck stops, and screeches to a U-Turn as the truck swivels, and COUNT and MARGO both scream again)

(Hard cut into OUTRO SONG, which the backing to was already playing on the radio.)

FIN.